

Haligric Research Integration Series

ISLAM AND SAMARITANISM

A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

Two Abrahamic Traditions, Compared in Full Depth

One grew from a cave on Mount Hira and now encompasses two billion souls.

*One kept the oldest fire burning on a mountain in the West Bank
and numbers approximately 900 people.*

Both begin with Abraham. Both turn to Moses.

Both say: there is no god but the One.

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim —

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful.

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PART ONE

Foundations

What Is Islam? Core Identity and Fast Facts

Islam (Arabic: submission or surrender to God) is the world's second-largest and fastest-growing religion — with approximately 2 billion followers as of 2025 (approximately 25-26% of the global population), up from 1.9 billion in 2020. It is a strictly monotheistic Abrahamic faith that teaches complete submission to the will of Allah (Arabic for "the God" — not a separate deity name but the Arabic word for God, used by Arab Christians too). A person who practices Islam is called a Muslim — Arabic for "one who submits." Islam understands itself not as a new religion but as the final, complete restoration of the original monotheism that God revealed to all prophets from Adam onward — a thread that runs through Judaism and Christianity but was, in the Islamic view, distorted over time until its perfect restoration through the Prophet Muhammad.

Fast facts: Founded 610 CE (first revelation) / 622 CE (Islamic calendar begins). Final Prophet: Muhammad ibn Abdullah (570-632 CE). Sacred Text: The Quran (also: Hadith collections). Holy City: Mecca (Saudi Arabia) — also Medina and Jerusalem. Major Branches: Sunni (~85-90%), Shia (~10-15%), Sufi (mystical tradition within both). Followers: ~2 billion worldwide (2025). Concentrated in: Middle East, North Africa, South/Southeast Asia, Sub-Saharan Africa. Islam is the fastest-growing major religion in the world (confirmed by Pew Research Center, June 2025).

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritanism is one of the world's oldest and smallest religions — a branch of ancient Israelite religion that diverged from mainstream Judaism approximately 2,500-2,800 years ago. As of 2024, approximately 900 Samaritans exist — the world's smallest surviving religious community — living in two communities: Kiryat Luza on Mount Gerizim in the West Bank (~380 people) and Holon near Tel Aviv (~460 people). This is one of the most dramatic contrasts in world religion: approximately 2 billion Muslims vs. approximately 900 Samaritans.*

Origins and History

From Arabia to the World

Pre-Islamic Arabia (Before 610 CE)

The Arabian Peninsula before Islam was a world of tribal polytheism, merchant culture, poetry, and oral tradition. The Ka'ba in Mecca — a cubic stone structure believed by Muslims to have been built by Abraham and his son Ishmael — housed 360 idols representing the deities of various tribes. Mecca was a major commercial and religious hub. Jewish and Christian communities existed across Arabia, and the concepts of monotheism, prophecy, and scripture were not unfamiliar — setting the stage for Muhammad's message to resonate.

The First Revelation (610 CE)

Muhammad ibn Abdullah, a 40-year-old merchant known for his honesty (nicknamed Al-Amin — "the trustworthy"), was meditating in a cave on Mount Hira outside Mecca when the angel Jibril (Gabriel) appeared and commanded: "Read!" (Iqra!). Muhammad, who could not read, was overwhelmed. The angel repeated the command three times, then recited the first verses of what would become the Quran. Muhammad returned home shaking, certain he had either encountered the divine or lost his mind. His wife Khadija, a wealthy businesswoman 15 years his senior who had proposed to him, embraced him, reassured him, and became the first Muslim. Her cousin Waraqa, a Christian scholar, confirmed that what Muhammad had experienced was the same revelation that had come to Moses.

Mecca, Medina, and the Hijra (610-632 CE)

For 13 years Muhammad preached in Mecca — facing mockery, social boycott, and eventually violence. In 622 CE he and his community made the Hijra (migration) to the city of Medina, where he was invited to lead as a statesman. This migration marks Year 1 of the Islamic calendar (AH — Anno Hegirae). In 630 CE Muhammad returned to Mecca with 10,000 followers, conquered it without significant bloodshed, and cleared the Ka'ba of idols. He died in 632 CE, having united most of the Arabian Peninsula under Islam.

The Rapid Expansion and Islamic Golden Age

Within 100 years of Muhammad's death, Islam had spread from Spain and Portugal in the west to the borders of China and India in the east — the fastest expansion of any religion or empire in history. The Islamic Golden Age (750-1258 CE) produced extraordinary achievements in mathematics, astronomy, medicine, philosophy, and architecture, preserving and advancing the knowledge of Greece and Rome while Europe was in its Dark Ages. Scholars including Al-Khwarizmi (algebra), Ibn Sina (medicine), Al-Ghazali (philosophy and theology), and Al-Biruni (history, anthropology) reshaped the intellectual world.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritanism has none of this missionary or expansionist history. While Islam spread from Arabia to encompass billions, the Samaritans remained a tiny, insular community rooted to Mount Gerizim. At their peak in the 4th-5th centuries CE they numbered perhaps 1-1.5 million. Today approximately 900 remain.*

The Prophet Muhammad

His Life and Mission

Muhammad is not worshipped by Muslims — he is emphatically human. But he is the most beloved figure in Islam: the seal of the prophets (Khatam an-Nabiyyin), the final messenger through whom God's complete guidance was delivered to humanity. His life (Sira) is studied in extraordinary detail as both biography and spiritual model.

Key dates: 570 CE — Born in Mecca to the Hashim clan of the Quraysh tribe. Father Abdullah died before his birth; mother Amina died when he was 6. Raised by grandfather Abd al-Muttalib, then uncle Abu Talib. 595 CE — Married Khadija bint Khuwaylid, a wealthy merchant widow who had employed him as a trade manager. She was his greatest supporter until her death. 610 CE — First revelation in the Cave of Hira. Begins preaching monotheism and social justice — care for the poor, freeing of slaves, equality before God. 619 CE — The "Year of Sorrow": both Khadija and Abu Talib (his protector) die. 620 CE — The Night Journey (Isra and Mi'raj): Muhammad is miraculously transported from Mecca to Jerusalem, then ascends through the seven heavens, meeting the prophets and receiving the command of five daily prayers. 622 CE — The Hijra to Medina. 630 CE — Conquest of Mecca. 632 CE — Death in Medina at approximately 62 years old.

When Muslims mention or write the Prophet's name, they traditionally follow it with "sallallahu alayhi wa sallam" (peace and blessings be upon him), often abbreviated as (PBUH) or (SAW) in writing.

Samaritanism

The Ancient Cousin Religion

Samaritanism is one of the world's oldest and smallest religions — a branch of ancient Israelite religion that diverged from mainstream Judaism approximately 2,500-2,800 years ago. As of 2024, approximately 900 Samaritans exist, living in two communities: Kiryat Luza on Mount Gerizim in the West Bank and Holon near Tel Aviv. The current (133rd) High Priest is Aabed-El ben Asher ben Matzliach, who has served since 2013, claiming direct descent from Aaron through his son Phinehas.

Origins — The Great Schism with Judaism

The Samaritan account: they are the true, unbroken descendants of the Israelite tribes of Ephraim and Manasseh, faithful to the original Torah of Moses, who never deviated. The Jewish account (reflected in 2 Kings 17): when the Assyrians conquered the northern Kingdom of Israel in 722 BCE, they resettled foreigners there who mixed with remaining Israelites and adopted a mixed religion. What is historically clear: by the time of Ezra and Nehemiah (5th century BCE), Samaritans and Jews were in sharp conflict over where God should be worshipped — Jerusalem (Jewish) or Mount Gerizim (Samaritan). The Samaritans built their own temple on Mount Gerizim; the Jews destroyed it in 128 BCE.

Core Samaritan Beliefs

One God (Yahweh/YHWH): Strict monotheism, no trinity, no second deity.

Moses is the only true prophet: No prophets after Moses. This is the most decisive Samaritan theological claim.

The Samaritan Pentateuch: The only true scripture — differs from the Jewish Masoretic text in approximately 6,000 places, most significantly identifying Mount Gerizim (not Jerusalem) as the holiest site.

Mount Gerizim as the holiest place on earth: The navel of the world, where Adam was created, where Noah's ark rested, where Abraham prepared to sacrifice Isaac.

The Taheb: A future redeemer figure ("the Restorer") who will come at the end of days — a Moses-like figure, not a Davidic king.

The Day of Judgment: Reward and punishment after death.

The Passover Sacrifice — The Oldest Continuously Performed Biblical Ritual

Samaritans' most spectacular ritual is the Passover sacrifice on Mount Gerizim. The entire Samaritan community climbs the mountain, the priests slaughter lambs at sunset (as commanded in Exodus 12), and the community cooks and eats the meal together before dawn — exactly as described in the Torah, making this the oldest continuously performed biblical ritual in the world. No other religious community has maintained this practice unbroken for 3,500+ years. The men dress in white; sheep blood is smeared on foreheads; the meat is roasted in great earthen pits over olive-wood fires. The whole community — half from Kiryat Luza on the mountain, half making the journey from Holon — gathers as one.

PART TWO

Belief and Scripture

The Six Articles of Faith (Iman)

While the Five Pillars describe what Muslims do, the Six Articles of Faith (Arkan al-Iman) describe what Muslims believe. Faith in all six is required for a person to be considered Muslim.

1. BELIEF IN ALLAH: Strict monotheism (tawhid) — there is one God, indivisible, without partners, parents, or children. Any association of partners with God (shirk) is the one unforgivable sin. God has 99 beautiful names (Asma ul-Husna) describing his attributes: Al-Rahman (the Merciful), Al-Rahim (the Compassionate), Al-Malik (the King), Al-Quddus (the Holy).

2. BELIEF IN THE ANGELS (MALA'IKA): Angels are beings created from light who obey God completely. Key angels: Jibril (Gabriel) who delivered revelation to prophets; Mikail (Michael) who oversees nature and provision; Israfil who will blow the trumpet at the Day of Judgment; Azrael (Malak al-Mawt) the angel of death. Two recording angels (Kiraman Katibin) accompany every person, recording good and bad deeds.

3. BELIEF IN THE DIVINE BOOKS (KUTUB): God revealed scriptures to various prophets: the Suhuf (scrolls) to Abraham, the Tawrat (Torah) to Moses, the Zabur (Psalms) to David, the Injil (Gospel) to Jesus, and finally the Quran to Muhammad — the final, complete, and preserved revelation. Muslims believe previous scriptures were divinely revealed but became corrupted through human transmission over time.

4. BELIEF IN THE PROPHETS (ANBIYA): God sent prophets to every nation throughout history to guide humanity. Islam counts 124,000 prophets in total; 25 are named in the Quran. Muhammad is the last and final prophet.

5. BELIEF IN THE DAY OF JUDGMENT (YAWM AL-QIYAMA): All humans will be resurrected and judged by God for their deeds. Those whose good deeds outweigh the bad will enter Jannah (paradise); those whose bad deeds outweigh will enter Jahannam (hellfire). God's mercy is the ultimate determining factor.

6. BELIEF IN DIVINE DECREE (QADAR): Everything that happens — good and bad — occurs by God's knowledge and permission. This does not eliminate human free will and responsibility; Muslims believe both coexist. This doctrine brings peace: whatever happens is within God's wisdom, even what we cannot understand.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON Samaritans share Articles 1, 5, and 6 with Islam — strict monotheism, divine decree, the Day of Judgment. They diverge sharply on Article 3: Samaritans accept only the Torah, rejecting all later scriptures including those Islam venerates. On Article 4: Samaritans accept Moses as the prophet but reject all prophets after him — David, Solomon, Isaiah, Jesus, and Muhammad are outside their prophetic framework.

The Quran

Structure, Revelation, and How to Approach It

The Quran (Arabic: Iqra — "recitation") is the literal word of God as revealed to Muhammad over 23 years (610-632 CE) through the angel Jibril. Muslims do not consider it a book Muhammad wrote or composed — it is God speaking in first person. This is why even touching the Quran requires ritual purity (wudu), and why memorizing it in Arabic — regardless of one's native language — is considered the highest religious act.

The Quran contains 114 chapters (suras), arranged not chronologically but roughly by length — from the longest (Al-Baqara, 286 verses) near the beginning to the shortest (3 verses each) at the end. The only exception is the opening chapter (Al-Fatiha — "The Opening"), which is 7 verses and is recited in every unit of every prayer. Each sura begins with "Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim" — "In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful." The Quran is divided into 30 equal sections (juz) to facilitate reading the entire text over 30 days.

Al-Fatiha — The Opening Chapter

Al-Fatiha is the most recited text in human history — a Muslim who prays five times daily recites it 17 times per day, over 6,000 times per year.

Bismillahi r-Rahmani r-Rahim

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful

Meaning: The opening invocation before the chapter begins

Al-hamdu lillahi rabbi l-'alamin

All praise is due to God, Lord of all the worlds

Meaning:

Ar-rahmani r-rahim. Maliki yawmi d-din

The Most Gracious, the Most Merciful. Master of the Day of Judgment

Meaning:

Iyyaka na'budu wa-iyyaka nasta'in

You alone we worship, and You alone we ask for help

Meaning: The pivot of the chapter — from description to direct address

Ihdina s-sirata l-mustaqim

Guide us to the straight path

Meaning:

Sirata lladhina an'amta 'alayhim ghayri l-maghdubi 'alayhim wa-la d-dallin. Amin

The path of those You have blessed — not of those who have earned anger, nor of those who have gone astray. Amen

Meaning: The petition that closes the chapter

The Hadith

The Prophet's Sayings and Sunna

The Quran is God's word. The Hadith are the recorded sayings, actions, and silent approvals of the Prophet Muhammad — collected and verified by Islamic scholars in the centuries after his death. Together with the Quran, they form the Sunna ("custom" or "practice") — the comprehensive model for Muslim life.

The science of Hadith authentication (Ilm al-Hadith) is one of the most rigorous in world scholarship. Every hadith has two parts: the matn (the content of what was said) and the isnad (the chain of transmitters going back to the Prophet). Scholars analyzed thousands of hadiths for reliability of the chain, character of each transmitter, and consistency with the Quran.

The Six Authentic Collections (Kutub al-Sitta): Sahih al-Bukhari (of 600,000 hadiths evaluated, only 7,275 were accepted — considered the most authentic). Sahih Muslim (3,033 unique hadiths — together with Bukhari called "the Two Sahihs"). Sunan Abu Dawud (5,274 hadiths, focuses heavily on legal matters). Sunan al-Tirmidhi (rates reliability of each hadith within the text itself). Sunan al-Nasa'i (known for its strict criteria; focuses on ritual matters). Sunan Ibn Majah (completes the six collections).

The Prophets of Islam

From Adam to Muhammad

Islam holds that God sent prophets to every nation throughout human history to guide people to the worship of one God and righteous living. The Quran names 25 prophets specifically. All are considered equally truthful messengers, though Muhammad holds the highest station as the final seal.

ADAM (ADEM): The first human and first prophet. Created from clay, breathed into by God. Unlike the Christian concept of Original Sin, Islam teaches that Adam and Hawwa (Eve) both repented and were fully forgiven. Their descent from paradise is not punishment but the beginning of humanity's earthly mission.

IBRAHIM (ABRAHAM): One of the five greatest prophets (Ulul 'Azm). The first to be called "the friend of God" (Khalilullah). Smashed his father's idols, was thrown into a fire by the king Nimrod (the fire became cool by God's command), and was commanded to sacrifice his son Ismail (Ishmael in the Islamic account, not Isaac). His willingness to obey is commemorated every year at Eid al-Adha. He and Ismail rebuilt the Ka'ba in Mecca.

MUSA (MOSES): The prophet to whom the Torah was revealed. Led the Israelites out of Egypt. Spoke directly with God on Mount Sinai. The Quran mentions Moses more than any other prophet — over 130 times. In the Night Journey (Isra and Mi'raj), Muhammad met Moses in the sixth heaven — Moses advised Muhammad to negotiate the number of daily prayers from 50 down to 5.

DAWUD (DAVID): The prophet to whom the Zabur (Psalms) was revealed. A king and warrior of great spiritual depth. His voice was so beautiful that mountains and birds sang with him when he praised God.

ISA (JESUS): Born of the virgin Maryam (Mary) — the Quran gives Maryam more attention than the New Testament does, and she has an entire chapter named after her (Sura Maryam). Isa performed miracles by God's permission: healing the blind, raising the dead, speaking as an infant. Islam firmly rejects the Trinity and the divinity of Jesus — he is a great prophet and messenger, not God. Islam also teaches that Jesus was not crucified — God raised him to heaven before the crucifixion. He will return before the Day of Judgment.

MUHAMMAD: The final and seal of all prophets. No prophet will come after him. His message is for all of humanity for all time. The Quran is his miracle — unlike Moses's staff or Jesus's healings, Muhammad's miracle is the text itself, considered inimitable in its linguistic perfection.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Moses (Musa) is where Islam and Samaritanism most powerfully converge — and most sharply diverge. Both traditions consider Moses the greatest human to whom God spoke directly. The divergence: Islam adds the entire chain of prophets after Moses — David, Solomon, Jesus, and finally Muhammad. Samaritanism stops completely at Moses. Any prophet after Moses is simply not recognized.*

The Samaritan Torah

How It Differs from the Islamic View

Both Islam and Samaritanism reference the Torah of Moses as a divine scripture. But what they mean by it, how they relate to it, and what they do with it are entirely different.

Is the Torah divine?: Islam — Yes — originally. But it has been altered and corrupted through human transmission over centuries. The Quran supersedes and corrects it where it has been changed. | Samaritanism — Yes — and it remains perfectly preserved exactly as Moses received it. The Samaritan Pentateuch is the pure original.

What about later Hebrew scriptures?: Islam — They are later revelations (Zabur to David, etc.) — all accepted as originally divine but now altered. | Samaritanism — Completely rejected. Only the Five Books of Moses are scripture.

Who interprets it?: Islam — The Quran, Hadith, and 1,400 years of Islamic scholarship guide interpretation. | Samaritanism — The Samaritan high priest and priestly lineage; their own commentary tradition.

Language of prayer?: Islam — Classical Arabic (Quranic Arabic). The Quran cannot be "translated" — only interpreted. | Samaritanism — Ancient Samaritan Hebrew — an archaic form of Hebrew preserved by the priestly tradition.

The single most significant textual difference: in the Jewish Masoretic text and in the Islamic understanding, the phrase "the place God will choose" to dwell refers to Jerusalem. In the Samaritan Pentateuch, every such phrase reads "the place God has chosen" — Mount Gerizim. This single textual variant is the theological foundation of the entire Samaritan-Jewish-Islamic disagreement about sacred geography.

PART THREE

The Five Pillars

Shahada

The Declaration of Faith

La ilaha illa Allah, Muhammadun rasul Allah

There is no god but God, and Muhammad is the messenger of God

The Shahada ("testimony" or "declaration") is the first and most fundamental pillar of Islam. To become Muslim, one need only sincerely declare this statement with full intention and understanding before witnesses. It is whispered into the ear of every newborn Muslim, and ideally the last words a Muslim speaks before death. The first part — "There is no god but God" — is the core of tawhid (monotheism). Notice the structure: it first negates all false gods ("no god") before affirming the one true God ("but God"). The second part — "Muhammad is the messenger of God" — affirms that the Quran and Sunna are the valid guide for Muslim life.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON Samaritans have their own central declaration: *"There is no God but One, and Moses is His prophet, and the Torah is Truth, and Mount Gerizim is the house of God."* This parallels the Shahada's structure — oneness of God, prophetic messenger, divine scripture — but freezes at Moses and adds the sacred mountain. Samaritans explicitly exclude Muhammad and the Quran from their confession of faith.

Salah

The Five Daily Prayers (Complete Guide)

Salah (also spelled Salat) is the ritual prayer performed five times daily by Muslims worldwide. A Muslim who lives to 70 performs approximately 127,750 prayers in their lifetime. Unlike spontaneous du'a (personal supplication), salah is a precise, structured ritual with specific postures, words, and times.

The five prayer times: Fajr (Dawn Prayer) — 2 units (rak'ahs) — between first light and sunrise. Dhuhhr (Midday Prayer) — 4 rak'ahs — after the sun passes its zenith. Asr (Afternoon Prayer) — 4 rak'ahs — mid-afternoon until just before sunset. Maghrib (Sunset Prayer) — 3 rak'ahs — just after sunset until twilight disappears. Isha (Night Prayer) — 4 rak'ahs — after twilight until midnight.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritans also pray three times daily — morning, afternoon, and evening — facing Mount Gerizim. The three-times vs. five-times difference originated in Muhammad's Night Journey — God originally commanded 50 daily prayers; Moses advised Muhammad to negotiate, and through multiple rounds it was reduced to five.*

Prayer Postures Explained

Every Movement and Its Meaning

A single unit of Islamic prayer (rak'ah) consists of a precise sequence of postures, each with specific words.

1. Niyyah — Intention

What you do: Standing upright, facing Mecca. Before raising the hands, the worshipper forms a silent intention in the heart: "I intend to pray [Fajr/Dhuhr/etc.] for the sake of God."

Meaning: Aligning the inner self with the outer act before it begins. The body faces Mecca; the heart faces God.

2. Takbir al-Ihram — Opening Exaltation

What you do: Both hands raised to ear level (palms facing forward), then lowered to the chest, right hand over left. Said aloud: "Allahu Akbar" (God is the Greatest).

Meaning: This gesture physically cuts off the worshipper from the world. You have entered a sacred threshold.

3. Qiyam — Standing

What you do: Standing upright, right hand over left at the chest, eyes cast downward. Recite Al-Fatiha (mandatory in every rak'ah). Then recite any additional passage from the Quran.

Meaning: Standing before God in attentiveness. The downward gaze represents humility — not looking upward toward heaven but inward and downward in awe.

4. Ruku — Bowing

What you do: Bending forward at the waist until the back is parallel to the ground, hands gripping the knees. Said three times: "Subhana Rabbi al-Azim" (Glory be to my Lord, the Magnificent).

Meaning: The bow acknowledges God's greatness and the worshipper's smallness. The spine is horizontal — the proudest part of the human body humbled.

5. I'tidal — Rising from the Bow

What you do: Returning to standing position, hands at sides. Said: "Sami Allahu liman hamidah" (God hears those who praise Him).

Meaning: God responds to praise. The rising from the bow represents the restoration — God lifts those who humble themselves.

6. Sujud — Prostration

What you do: THE most important posture. Descend to the ground: knees first, then hands, then forehead and nose simultaneously. Seven body parts must touch: forehead+nose, two palms, two knees, toes of both feet. Said three times: "Subhana Rabbi al-A'la" (Glory be to my Lord, the Most High).

Meaning: The highest part of the human body — the forehead, seat of reason and pride — touches the lowest place: the ground. "The closest a servant is to his Lord is when he is in prostration." The phrase "Most High" is said while the body is at its lowest — the theological paradox is deliberate.

7. Julus — Sitting between Prostrations

What you do: Rising from prostration to a seated position. Said: "Rabbighfir li" (My Lord, forgive me).

Meaning: A moment to ask forgiveness before returning to the ground again.

8. Sujud — Second Prostration

What you do: The same prostration repeated. Said three times again: "Subhana Rabbiy al-A'la."

Meaning: The second prostration completes one rak'ah. Each unit contains two prostrations — the prayer returns to its deepest point twice.

9. Tashahhud — The Testimony (Final Sitting)

What you do: In the final rak'ah, the worshipper sits with the right index finger raised (the tasbih gesture). Recites the Tashahhud — the declaration of God's oneness and the greeting of peace to the Prophet and the community.

Meaning: The raised index finger during the Tashahhud is a physical declaration of tawhid — one finger, one God. The greeting of peace connects every Muslim to every other Muslim across time and space.

10. Taslim — The Closing

What you do: Turning the head to the right: "As-salamu alaykum wa rahmatullah" (Peace and God's mercy be upon you). Then turning to the left and repeating.

Meaning: The worshipper returns from the presence of God into the world by offering peace in both directions.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritan prayer postures are strikingly similar to Islamic salah — standing, bowing, and full prostration facing Mount Gerizim. This similarity is not coincidental: both traditions draw from ancient Semitic worship practices. Both Islam and Samaritanism preserved this ancient bodily practice while Judaism gradually moved toward a prayer style that is primarily standing.*

Zakat — Obligatory Charity

Zakat (purification) is the mandatory annual giving of 2.5% of one's savings and accumulated wealth above a minimum threshold (nisab — equivalent to approximately 85 grams of gold) to those in need. It is not optional charity — it is a pillar of faith, as obligatory as prayer. The Quran pairs zakat with salah more than 80 times — they are inseparable. Zakat purifies wealth by acknowledging that all wealth ultimately belongs to God, and the poor have a right to a portion of it. Recipients include: the poor, the destitute, those in debt, travelers in need, and those working to collect and distribute zakat.

Zakat vs. Sadaqa: Zakat is obligatory and calculated precisely. Sadaqa is voluntary charity — any act of generosity, including a smile or kind word. The Prophet said: "Every good deed is sadaqa." Muslims are encouraged to give both.

Sawm — Fasting in Ramadan

Ramadan is the 9th month of the Islamic lunar calendar — the month in which the first verses of the Quran were revealed to Muhammad. For the entire month, Muslims who are able fast from Fajr (dawn) until Maghrib (sunset) — no food, no water, no smoking, no sexual relations, no lying or backbiting. The fast is broken each evening with iftar ("breaking the fast") — traditionally beginning with dates and water, following the Prophet's practice. The pre-dawn meal (suhoor) is eaten before Fajr. Eid al-Fitr on the final day is one of the greatest celebrations in the Islamic year.

Fasting is exempted for: the ill, elderly, pregnant or nursing women, travelers, and children. Missed days are made up later or compensated by feeding the poor. Laylat al-Qadr — The Night of Power: In the last ten days of Ramadan (most likely the 27th night), the Night of Power falls — the night the first Quran verses were revealed. The Quran says this night is "better than a thousand months." Muslims spend it in intense prayer, Quran recitation, and worship.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritans fast on Yom Kippur (the Day of Atonement) and several other days tied to the Torah calendar. Their fasting is absolute — no food, no water, no bathing. The Ramadan concept of an entire month's daily fast with communal breaking of the fast each evening has no equivalent in Samaritanism.*

Hajj — The Pilgrimage to Mecca

Every Muslim who is physically and financially able must perform Hajj — the pilgrimage to Mecca — at least once in their lifetime. It occurs in the Islamic month of Dhu al-Hijja and draws 2-3 million pilgrims annually, making it the largest annual human gathering on earth.

IHRAM: Upon approaching Mecca, pilgrims enter a state of ihram — donning two seamless white cloths (men) or modest white clothing (women), symbolizing equality before God. All pilgrims look the same: no distinction of wealth, race, or nationality.

TAWAF: Circumambulating the Ka'ba seven times counterclockwise. The Ka'ba — a cube-shaped stone structure draped in black cloth embroidered in gold — is the focal point of all Islamic prayer worldwide. According to Islamic tradition, it was first built by Adam and rebuilt by Ibrahim and Ismail.

SA'I: Walking seven times between the hills of Safa and Marwa, commemorating Hajar (Hagar) — Ibrahim's wife — desperately searching for water for her infant son Ismail. God caused the spring of Zamzam to burst from the ground. Pilgrims drink Zamzam water throughout Hajj.

WUQUF AT ARAFAT: Standing on the plain of Arafat from noon to sunset — the spiritual heart of Hajj. The Prophet said: "Hajj is Arafat." Pilgrims pray, supplicate, and seek forgiveness.

RAMI AL-JAMARAT: Throwing pebbles at three stone pillars representing the devil — commemorating Ibrahim's rejection of Shaytan when the devil tried to dissuade him from sacrificing Ismail.

EID AL-ADHA: Animal sacrifice commemorating Ibrahim's willingness to sacrifice Ismail. The meat is divided: one third for the family, one third for relatives, one third for the poor.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *The Samaritan equivalent of pilgrimage is the three annual ascents of Mount Gerizim — for Passover, Shavuot (Feast of Weeks), and Sukkot (Tabernacles). The Passover ascent is the most dramatic: the entire Samaritan community climbs the mountain and camps there for the duration. For Samaritans, Gerizim is the Ka'ba — the axis mundi, the navel of the earth, the place where heaven and earth touch.*

PART FOUR

Worship and Practice

The Mosque

Architecture, Etiquette, and Jumu'ah

The word masjid (mosque) means "place of prostration." A mosque's essential elements: a prayer hall (musalla) with a clear wall facing Mecca, a niche (mihrab) indicating the Qibla direction, a pulpit (minbar) for the Friday sermon, and a place for ablution (wudu area). Large mosques add minarets (towers from which the call to prayer is given) and a dome (which improves acoustics and symbolizes the vault of heaven).

Mosque etiquette: Remove shoes at the entrance. Dress modestly — shoulders and knees covered for all; women cover their hair. Men and women typically pray in separate sections. Enter with the right foot and say "Bismillah." Perform wudu before entering the prayer hall. Do not walk in front of a person who is praying. Non-Muslims are welcome to observe in most mosques — you are not required to pray. Leave with the left foot.

Jumu'ah — Friday Prayer: Friday (Jumu'ah) is the Islamic holy day. The Dhuhr (midday) prayer on Friday is replaced by a congregational prayer with a sermon (khutbah). The imam delivers two sermons before the prayer, typically in Arabic with translation, covering religious, moral, or community topics. This prayer is obligatory for adult Muslim men.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritanism's holy day is the Sabbath — Saturday — strictly observed from sunset Friday to Saturday nightfall. No fire, no electricity, no cooking, no travel, no writing. This is more strictly observed than in most Jewish communities today. The Samaritan Sabbath has no equivalent of the Islamic Friday communal sermon — it is a day of complete cessation and prayer at the synagogue on Mount Gerizim.*

Wudu — Ritual Purification Step by Step

Before salah (prayer) or touching the Quran, a Muslim must be in a state of ritual purity (tahara). Wudu is the minor purification — performed with clean water, it purifies specific body parts in a prescribed sequence.

- 1. Intention:** Form the silent intention to purify for the sake of God.
- 2. Bismillah:** Say: "Bismillahi r-Rahmani r-Rahim" (In the name of God...).
- 3. Wash hands:** Wash both hands up to the wrists three times, between the fingers.
- 4. Rinse mouth:** Take water in the right hand and rinse the mouth three times.
- 5. Sniff water:** Take water into the nostrils and blow out three times (istinshaq).
- 6. Wash face:** Wash the entire face from hairline to chin, ear to ear, three times.
- 7. Wash arms:** Wash right arm from fingertips to elbow three times, then left arm.
- 8. Wipe head:** Wet both hands and wipe them over the head once — front to back.
- 9. Wipe ears:** Using the wet hands, wipe inside and behind both ears once.
- 10. Wash feet:** Wash right foot up to the ankle three times (between toes), then left.

The Call to Prayer (Adhan)

Full Text and Meaning

The Adhan is called five times daily from mosques worldwide — one of the most beautiful and recognized sounds in human civilization. It is also whispered into the right ear of every newborn Muslim. The Adhan was established by Muhammad, who chose Bilal ibn Rabah — a freed Ethiopian slave — to be the first mu'adhdhin (one who calls the adhan) because of his powerful voice. Bilal's selection was itself a statement of Islam's equality: the first voice to call humanity to prayer was a formerly enslaved African man.

Allahu Akbar (x4)

God is the Greatest

Meaning: Said four times to open — the world's concerns are set aside. God is greater than everything you were just doing.

Ashhadu alla ilaha illa Allah (x2)

I testify there is no god but God

Meaning: The first half of the Shahada.

Ashhadu anna Muhammadan rasul Allah (x2)

I testify that Muhammad is the messenger of God

Meaning: The second half of the Shahada.

Hayya 'ala s-Salah (x2)

Come to prayer

Meaning: Turning right while calling — directing the invitation.

Hayya 'ala l-Falah (x2)

Come to success/flourishing

Meaning: Turning left — "falah" means ultimate success in both this life and the next.

As-Salatu khayrun min an-nawm (x2) — Fajr only

Prayer is better than sleep

Meaning: The unique addition to the dawn call — an acknowledgment that waking before sunrise is hard, and an encouragement that it is worth it.

Allahu Akbar (x2), La ilaha illa Allah (x1)

God is the Greatest. There is no god but God.

Meaning: The closing affirmation and seal of the call.

Islamic Calendar, Festivals, and Holy Days

The Islamic calendar is lunar — 12 months of 29 or 30 days each, totaling 354 days per year. Because it is not adjusted to the solar year (unlike the Jewish calendar which adds a leap month), Islamic holidays cycle through all seasons over a 33-year period.

EID AL-FITR (1 Shawwal — end of Ramadan): The "Festival of Breaking the Fast" — one of the two great Eids. A day of celebration, gift-giving, new clothes, family gatherings, and prayers. Marks the end of the month of fasting.

EID AL-ADHA (10-13 Dhu al-Hijja — during Hajj season): The "Festival of Sacrifice" — the greater of the two Eids. Commemorates Ibrahim's willingness to sacrifice Ismail. Animal sacrifice is performed worldwide.

LAYLAT AL-QADR (one of the last 10 nights of Ramadan, likely the 27th): The Night of Power — the holiest night of the year. Intense prayer, Quran recitation, and worship. "Better than a thousand months."

MAWLID AL-NABI (12 Rabi' al-Awwal): The Prophet's birthday. Celebrated in many Muslim communities with prayers, poetry, and gatherings. (Not universally observed — some scholars consider it an innovation.)

ISLAMIC NEW YEAR (Muharram 1): The new year, marked quietly. The 10th of Muharram (Ashura) is of great significance — for Sunnis, a day of optional fasting; for Shia Muslims, a day of deep mourning commemorating the martyrdom of Husayn ibn Ali at Karbala (680 CE).

ISRA AND MI'RAJ (27 Rajab): Commemorating the Night Journey — Muhammad's miraculous transport to Jerusalem and ascent through the seven heavens.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritans follow a strictly Torah-based calendar — the same three pilgrimage festivals commanded in the Torah: Passover (Pesach), Feast of Weeks (Shavuot), and Feast of Tabernacles (Sukkot). They also observe Yom Kippur and Rosh Hashanah. No additional holidays have been added in 3,500 years. Their calendar is solar-lunar with a leap month added to stay aligned to seasons, unlike the purely lunar Islamic calendar.*

Halal and Haram — Dietary Laws and Daily Ethics

Halal (Arabic: permissible) and Haram (Arabic: forbidden) are the two poles of Islamic law governing all of life — not just food but financial dealings, relationships, speech, and entertainment.

HALAL MEAT: Animals must be slaughtered by a Muslim (or People of the Book) with the name of God spoken ("Bismillah, Allahu Akbar"), the throat cut swiftly to minimize suffering, and the blood drained.

FORBIDDEN (HARAM): Pork and all pork products, alcohol and intoxicants, blood, carrion (animals not properly slaughtered), animals slaughtered in the name of anyone other than God.

SEAFOOD: Generally halal — fish with scales are unanimously permitted; opinion varies on shellfish.

GELATIN: A common concern — pork-derived gelatin in sweets and capsules is haram; halal-certified alternatives exist.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritan dietary laws are based strictly on Leviticus and Deuteronomy as interpreted by their own tradition — no pork, no blood, no mixing of meat and dairy. Their slaughter method (similar to Islamic halal in requiring a swift, humane cut and specific divine invocation) reflects the same underlying principle: acknowledging God's ownership of all life.*

PART FIVE

Dress, Law, and Branches

Islamic Dress

Hijab, Niqab, Abaya, and Male Dress Explained

Islamic dress is rooted in the concept of hijab — a word that means "covering" or "screen," not only the headscarf but the broader principle of modest presentation. The Quran instructs both men and women to dress modestly and guard their gaze.

Women's Dress

HIJAB: The head covering worn by Muslim women — covering the hair, neck, and ears while leaving the face visible. The most common form of Islamic modest dress globally. Worn by women who choose it as an act of worship, identity, modesty, and devotion. NOT a sign of oppression in itself — many Muslim women wear it proudly and by choice; others are pressured into it by family or state. The distinction matters enormously.

NIQAB: A face veil that covers everything except the eyes. Worn in addition to the hijab. More common in Gulf Arab culture. The majority of Islamic scholars consider it recommended but not obligatory; a minority consider it obligatory.

ABAYA: A long, loose robe — typically black — worn over clothing. Common in the Arabian Peninsula. Primarily a cultural garment from Gulf Arab culture that has spread globally.

JILBAB: A loose, full-length outer garment — similar to an abaya but not necessarily black; can be any color. More common in South and Southeast Asian Muslim communities.

CHADOR: A full-body covering — a large semicircular cloth covering the head and body but leaving the face visible. Common in Iran.

Men's Dress

The minimum Islamic requirement for men is covering from navel to knee. Key garments: Thobe/Dishdasha (long white robe common in Arab countries — practical, cool, and modest in desert climates). Kufi/Taqiyah (small rounded skullcap worn during prayer and by many devout Muslim men as a daily sign of religious identity). Western clothing is entirely acceptable in Islam as long as it meets modesty requirements. Beards: the Prophet kept a beard; many Muslim men grow one as Sunna.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON Samaritan dress has no equivalent to the hijab or Islamic modest dress codes. Samaritan women do not traditionally cover their hair in daily life. During the Passover sacrifice on Mount Gerizim, all Samaritans dress in white — symbolizing purity — which has a spiritual parallel to the ihram white garments of Hajj pilgrims. The priests wear specific white priestly garments during rituals.

Sunni, Shia, and Sufi — The Major Branches

The Origin of the Split — 632 CE

When Muhammad died without designating a clear successor, the Muslim community faced its first great crisis. Two positions emerged: The majority (who became Sunni) held that the community should choose the best qualified leader through consultation — they supported Abu Bakr as the first Caliph. A minority (who became Shia — from "Shi'at Ali," "the party of Ali") held that leadership should have passed to Ali ibn Abi Talib — Muhammad's cousin and son-in-law. They believed Ali was divinely designated by Muhammad at Ghadir Khumm. The split became permanent and violent at the Battle of Karbala (680 CE), when Husayn ibn Ali — grandson of the Prophet — was killed by the Umayyad Caliph's army. This event is the defining tragedy of Shia Islam, commemorated every year during Ashura.

Sunni Islam (~85-90% of Muslims)

Sunni Islam recognizes four schools of Islamic law (madhabs), all considered equally valid: Hanafi (most widespread globally), Maliki (North and West Africa), Shafi'i (East Africa, Southeast Asia), and Hanbali (Arabian Peninsula). Sunnis do not have a central religious authority. Al-Azhar University in Cairo is one of the most prestigious Islamic scholarly institutions.

Shia Islam (~10-15% of Muslims)

Shia Islam centers on the authority of the Imams — descendants of Ali and Fatima who are considered divinely guided interpreters of Islam. The largest Shia branch (Twelver Shia, dominant in Iran, Iraq, Lebanon, Bahrain) awaits the return of the 12th Imam — Muhammad al-Mahdi — who went into occultation (hiddenness) in 874 CE and will return at the end of times.

Sufism — The Mystical Heart of Islam

Sufism (tasawwuf) is not a separate sect but a dimension of Islamic spirituality that exists within both Sunni and Shia traditions. Sufis seek direct inner experience of God — not just ritual compliance but the transformation of the heart into a mirror of the divine. Sufi practices include: dhikr (rhythmic repetition of God's names), sama (sacred music and sometimes whirling dance — the Mevlevi "Whirling Dervishes" of Turkey follow the 13th-century poet-mystic Rumi), murshid-murid relationships (spiritual master and student), and retreat (khalwa). Great Sufi poets — Rumi, Hafiz, Ibn Arabi, Rabia al-Adawiyya — produced some of the world's most beautiful spiritual literature.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON *Samaritanism has no equivalent to the Sunni/Shia division or to Sufi mysticism. It has remained a single, unified religious community with no major internal splits — partly because its tiny size made schism impractical, and partly because the priestly hierarchy provides clear religious authority.*

Sharia — Islamic Law Explained Clearly

Sharia (Arabic: "the path to the watering hole") is Islamic law — the comprehensive framework derived from the Quran and Sunna that guides Muslim life. It is widely misunderstood in Western contexts, where it is often associated only with harsh criminal punishments. In reality, the vast majority of Sharia concerns personal religious practice, family law, and ethics.

The five categories of human action in Islamic law: Fard (Obligatory) — must be done; failure is sinful: the five prayers, fasting Ramadan, paying zakat. Mustahabb (Recommended) — rewarded if done; no sin if omitted: praying voluntary prayers, giving extra charity. Mubah (Neutral) — neither rewarded nor punished: most everyday activities. Makruh (Disliked) — discouraged but not sinful: wasting food, being harsh in speech, excessive sleep. Haram (Forbidden) — must not be done; violation is sinful: alcohol, pork, adultery, theft, lying, murder.

SAMARITANISM COMPARISON Samaritan religious law is derived entirely from the Torah as interpreted by their priestly tradition. Like Sharia, it covers diet, purity, Sabbath observance, marriage, and ritual. But where Sharia has 1,400 years of elaboration by thousands of scholars across many cultures, Samaritan law is more contained — developed by a tiny community's priests over millennia. Samaritan marriage law is the strictest parallel: Samaritans may only marry other Samaritans. As the community has shrunk to ~900 people, this has created serious genetic and demographic challenges.

Islam vs. Samaritanism — Side-by-Side Comparison

Followers: Islam — ~2 billion worldwide (2025) | Samaritanism — ~900 — the world's smallest religion (2024)

Origin: Islam — Arabia, 610 CE | Samaritanism — Ancient Israel; diverged ~8th-5th century BCE

God: Islam — Allah — one God, no partners | Samaritanism — Yahweh — one God, no partners

Core declaration: Islam — La ilaha illa Allah, Muhammadun rasul Allah | Samaritanism — "There is no God but One, Moses is His prophet, the Torah is Truth, and Mount Gerizim is the house of God"

Sacred text: Islam — The Quran (God's word) + Hadith | Samaritanism — The Samaritan Pentateuch (Torah only)

Prophets: Islam — Adam through Muhammad (25 named; Muhammad is the last) | Samaritanism — Moses only — no prophets before or after are recognized in the same way

Jesus: Islam — Prophet (Isa), not divine; not crucified; will return | Samaritanism — Not recognized as a prophet

Holy place: Islam — Mecca (Ka'ba); also Medina and Jerusalem | Samaritanism — Mount Gerizim (West Bank) — exclusively

Prayer direction: Islam — Facing Mecca (Qibla) | Samaritanism — Facing Mount Gerizim

Prayer times: Islam — 5 times daily | Samaritanism — 3 times daily

Prayer postures: Islam — Standing, bowing, full prostration | Samaritanism — Standing, bowing, full prostration — very similar

Sabbath: Islam — Friday Jumu'ah prayer; no full day of rest | Samaritanism — Full Sabbath (Saturday) — strict rest, no fire/electricity

Calendar: Islam — Purely lunar (shifts through seasons) | Samaritanism — Solar-lunar (adjusted, stays seasonal)

Major festivals: Islam — Eid al-Fitr, Eid al-Adha, Ramadan | Samaritanism — Passover, Shavuot, Sukkot, Yom Kippur

Pilgrimage: Islam — Hajj to Mecca (once in lifetime if able) | Samaritanism — Three annual ascents of Mount Gerizim

Marriage: Islam — Marriage to non-Muslims historically debated; varies | Samaritanism — May only marry other Samaritans (endogamous)

Mysticism: Islam — Sufism — a rich mystical tradition within Islam | Samaritanism — None — no equivalent mystical tradition

Branches: Islam — Sunni, Shia, Sufi (and many smaller groups) | Samaritanism — One unified community with no major branches

Islam in the World Today

Islam is the world's fastest-growing major religion, confirmed by the Pew Research Center's landmark June 2025 demographic study. From 2010 to 2020, the global Muslim population grew by 347 million people — more than all other religions combined. This single decade's Muslim growth exceeded the total number of Buddhists worldwide in 2020 (324 million). In 2010, Muslims made up 23.9% of the world's population and Christians accounted for 30.6%. By 2020, Muslims accounted for 25.6% and Christians 28.8%. The gap is shrinking: by 2050, Pew projects near-parity between Muslims (~2.8 billion, or 30% of global population) and Christians (~2.9 billion, or 31%).

The primary driver is not conversion but demographics: Muslims have the youngest median age (approximately 24 years) among major religious groups and the highest fertility rate (approximately 2.9 children per woman on average, compared to 2.2 for non-Muslim women). As of 2025, the global Muslim population is estimated at approximately 2 billion, representing approximately 25-26% of the world's population. Indonesia leads with around 240 million Muslims. Pakistan and India follow closely — India, despite being majority-Hindu, is home to over 200 million Muslims. In North America, the Muslim population grew by 52% from 2010 to 2020, now totaling approximately 5.9 million in the US. There are approximately 44 million Muslims in Europe (excluding Turkey), representing approximately 6% of the European population, with the fastest growth in Germany, France, and the UK.

Islam is also a major cultural force in the contemporary world: Islamic finance (which prohibits *riba* — usury/interest and operates on profit-sharing principles) has grown to over \$3 trillion in global assets. The Hajj (with 2-3 million pilgrims annually) is the largest annual peaceful human gathering on earth. The Arabic language — the language of the Quran — is spoken by approximately 370 million people as a first language and is one of the six official languages of the United Nations. The Sufi tradition continues to produce some of the world's most vital spiritual literature and practice; the poetry of Rumi remains among the bestselling poetry in the United States.

Bismillah ir-Rahman ir-Rahim —

In the name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful.

Two ancient paths, rooted in the same soil of Abrahamic faith — one that spread to encompass two billion souls, one that retreated to a mountain and kept the oldest fire burning. Both begin with Abraham. Both say the name of Moses. Both prostrate. Both face their sacred direction and speak, five times daily or three, the same essential recognition: there is no god but the One. Grand Rising.